



OJAI FOR WHO?

Ojai has many glorious native animals that contribute to the valley’s mystical and special character. There are bears. There are coyotes. There are raccoons (lots of raccoons). There are bobcats. There are butterflies. There are birds (not pictured). But Ojai also has other things. Among those things are many, many single family houses. Ah yes, the lovely sprawl of southern California. As Ojai’s footprint has expanded over the last century, the native animals footprint has only gotten smaller. Where are they to go? Coyotes roam the streets their ancestor s once did, but now they roam desperate and in fear. Humans look at them and call them monster. Do they go after our dogs? Yes. But this was their home too and it doesnt help that our small dogs probably look really tasty to them. I would be angry if a coyote ate my small dog Peaches, but I would not blame the coyote. Are dogs related to coyotes? Are wolves? On another note, Ojai is just filled with raccoons galore! They move around in their little groups with there burglaresque hands like they own the town, and in my book,

they should! Imagine a town run by raccoon. Do you think they would uphold democracy? Or do they have a completely different governmental structure? Imagine their little hands with a little gavel, laying down the law like its no ones business. This was about single family homes. If you look at my fancy chart to the left right over here you will see Ojai has been on par with the rest of California in building single family homes. Of course the numbers are lower because, well, Ojai is only comprised of approximately 7,500 people. There may be just as many squirrels as there are people. There are so many squirrels in Ojai. I used ot have a corner office with a big window that faced a tree and I saw so many squirrels from my desk. In the springtime they go crazy. Jumping all over the place. Once, a squirrel accidentally parkoured off of my legs. I accepted it, becuase this is their town too. And that is what I am trying to get at here. We all belong. I hope one day, I can walk down the sidewalks, into the arcade plaza alongside a black bear (they’re the nicer ones). Maybe exposure therapy will keep them from hurting me. Maybe they want to shop at Rainbow Bridge grocery store and eat at Jim and Robs -- get

a california burrito. California bears should eat California burritos. Wicked comes into theaters in a week. That’s right! Wicked talks about this, actually. When Dr. Dillamond sings “Something Bad”, he expresses how the animals are slowly being banished from Oz. Maybe that is our history. Maybe we have forgotten the connection we have had to the animals. Ironically, we sit in our single-family homes and watch movies like Pocahontas with songs like “Colors of the Wind”. “But I know every rock and tree and creature, has a life, has a spirit, has a name”. I believe that. We are all one and I hope one day we can all coexist and live our lives in happiness and joy. Humans, raccoons, bobcats, wicked witches of the west, goat teachers, butterflies, black bears, brown bears, orcas, and caterpillars.

My name is Sarah Kameli and I approve this message. So does my dog Peaches, but she is not here.

